The French Revolution

The big idea

In 1789 the people of France rose against a king who ruled with absolute power and a society that made the poor pay for the luxuries of the rich. The French Revolution gave the world the ideas of **liberty, equality and fraternity**, and the belief that power belongs to the people, not to a king chosen by birth or "by God".

KEY DATES AT A GLANCE

1774 Louis XVI becomes king · **5 May 1789** Estates General meets · **20 June 1789** Tennis Court Oath · **14 July 1789** Storming of the Bastille · **1791** Constitution makes France a constitutional monarchy · **1792** France becomes a republic · **1793** Louis XVI executed; Reign of Terror (1793–94) · **1795** Directory · **1799** Napoleon seizes power · **1848** slavery finally abolished in French colonies · **1946** women in France get the vote.

French society in the late 18th century

When Louis XVI (of the **Bourbon** family) became king at the age of 20, the treasury was empty. Long wars, the upkeep of the grand palace at **Versailles**, and helping the thirteen American colonies win independence from Britain had pushed France into a debt of over **2 billion livres**. To meet costs, the state raised taxes.

French society was divided into three **Estates** (the "Old Regime", or *ancien régime*):

Estate	Who	Tax position
First	Clergy	Exempt from taxes to the state
Second	Nobility	Exempt; enjoyed feudal privileges
Third	Merchants, lawyers, officials, peasants, artisans, servants (about 90% of people)	Paid all the taxes

Peasants paid **taille** (a direct tax to the state), indirect taxes on salt and tobacco, **tithes** (one-tenth of produce to the Church) and feudal dues to nobles.

Subsistence crisis: population rose from about 23 million (1715) to 28 million (1789). Grain production could not keep up, so the price of bread (the staple food) shot up while wages did not. A drought or hailstorm could leave the poor without food. This is called a subsistence crisis.

The middle class (merchants, lawyers, administrators) were educated and wealthy, yet had no privileges. They were inspired by philosophers:

- **John Locke** (Two Treatises of Government) rejected the divine and absolute right of the king.
- **Rousseau** (The Social Contract) proposed government based on a contract between people and their representatives.
- **Montesquieu** (The Spirit of the Laws) proposed **separation of powers** among the legislative, executive and judiciary.

Outbreak of the revolution

On **5 May 1789** Louis XVI called the **Estates General** (last called in 1614) to approve new taxes. Each Estate traditionally had one vote. The Third Estate demanded **one vote per member**. When the king refused, its members walked out and on **20 June** gathered at an indoor tennis court, declaring themselves the **National Assembly** and swearing not to disperse until they had drafted a

constitution (the **Tennis Court Oath**). They were led by **Mirabeau** (a noble) and **Abbé Sieyès** (a priest, author of the pamphlet "What is the Third Estate?").

On **14 July 1789** an angry crowd stormed the **Bastille**, a fortress-prison hated as a symbol of the king's despotic power. In the countryside, rumours spread that lords had hired bands to destroy crops; in this **Great Fear** peasants burnt manor records. The king gave in and on the night of **4 August 1789** the Assembly abolished feudal obligations and tithes; Church lands were confiscated.

The **Constitution of 1791** made France a **constitutional monarchy**: the king's powers were divided among the legislature, executive and judiciary. But only **active citizens** (men over 25 who paid taxes equal to at least 3 days' wages) could vote. Women, children and poor men were **passive citizens**. The Constitution began with the **Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen** (right to life, freedom of speech, freedom of opinion, equality before law).

Abolition of monarchy and the Reign of Terror

The **Jacobin Club**, led by **Maximilien Robespierre**, drew poorer sections: shopkeepers, artisans, servants and daily wagers. They wore long striped trousers and were called **sans-culottes** ("those without knee breeches"). In August 1792 they stormed the Tuileries palace. Elections were held in which all men over 21 could vote, and the new assembly, the **Convention**, abolished the monarchy on **21 September 1792**. France became a **republic**. Louis XVI was executed for treason in **January 1793**, and Queen Marie Antoinette soon after.

Reign of Terror (1793–1794): Robespierre punished all those he saw as enemies of the republic with the **guillotine**. He also ordered rationing of bread (the "bread of equality"), fixed maximum wages and prices, and closed churches. In **July 1794** he himself was guillotined.

After this a **Directory** of five members ran the government, but political instability let **Napoleon Bonaparte** seize power in 1799. He crowned himself emperor in 1804.

REPUBLIC VS CONSTITUTIONAL MONARCHY

In 1791 France still had a king, with limited powers. It became a **republic** only in **1792**. Do not mix the two.

Did women have a revolution?

Women of the Third Estate worked as seamstresses, laundresses, flower and vegetable sellers, or domestic servants. They had little access to education or job training. They started around **60 women's clubs**; the most famous was the **Society of Revolutionary and Republican Women**. They demanded the right to vote, to be elected and to hold office.

Early gains: state schools and compulsory schooling for girls; marriage became a contract entered freely and registered under civil law; divorce was made legal. But during the Terror women's clubs were closed. **Olympe de Gouges** wrote a declaration of the rights of women and was executed in 1793. French women won the vote only in **1946**.

Slavery: France ran a triangular slave trade between Europe, Africa and the Americas (ports Bordeaux and Nantes). The Convention freed slaves in French colonies in **1794**, Napoleon reintroduced slavery, and it was finally abolished in **1848**.

Legacy

- Ideas of **liberty and democratic rights** spread across Europe in the 19th century; feudal systems were abolished.
- Colonised peoples (for example **Tipu Sultan** and **Raja Rammohan Roy** in India) were inspired by the ideas of the Revolution.
- Censorship ended; newspapers, pamphlets, plays and songs spread ideas to people who could not read.

SYMBOLS OF THE REVOLUTION

Broken chain (freedom), bundle of rods or fasces (strength lies in unity), eye within a triangle radiating light (knowledge), sceptre (royal power), snake biting its tail (eternity), red Phrygian cap (freedom), blue-white-red (national colours), winged woman (the law), law tablet (equality before law).

BOARD FAVOURITE

"Explain the causes of the French Revolution" is asked almost every year. Write: social inequality of estates, empty treasury and taxes, subsistence crisis, rise of the middle class, and philosophers' ideas.

Quick recap

- Three Estates: only the Third Estate paid taxes.
- 1789: Estates General → Tennis Court Oath → fall of Bastille (14 July).
- 1791 constitutional monarchy; 1792 republic; 1793–94 Reign of Terror under Robespierre.
- Women's clubs fought for rights; vote only in 1946. Slavery abolished in 1848.
- Legacy: liberty, equality, fraternity and the idea of people's sovereignty.

Practice questions

1. Which event of 14 July 1789 is seen as the start of the French Revolution?
   (a) The Tennis Court Oath (b) The storming of the Bastille (c) The execution of Louis XVI (d) The meeting of the Estates General
2. The tax paid directly to the state by peasants in France was called
   (a) tithe (b) livre (c) taille (d) corvée
3. Who wrote "The Spirit of the Laws" proposing separation of powers?
   (a) Rousseau (b) John Locke (c) Mirabeau (d) Montesquieu
4. Under the Constitution of 1791, who were "active citizens"?
   (a) Men above 25 who paid taxes equal to at least 3 days of a labourer's wage (b) All men and women above 21 (c) Only nobles and clergy (d) All property-owning women
5. The Reign of Terror is associated with
   (a) Napoleon Bonaparte (b) Louis XVI (c) Maximilien Robespierre (d) Abbé Sieyès
6. In which year were women in France finally given the right to vote?
   (a) 1792 (b) 1848 (c) 1804 (d) 1946
7. The red Phrygian cap worn by the sans-culottes symbolised
   (a) royal power (b) freedom (c) eternity (d) equality before law
8. Describe the circumstances that led to the outbreak of revolutionary protest in France.
9. What were the main features of the Constitution of 1791? Which groups did it leave out?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. b 8. see notes 9. see notes